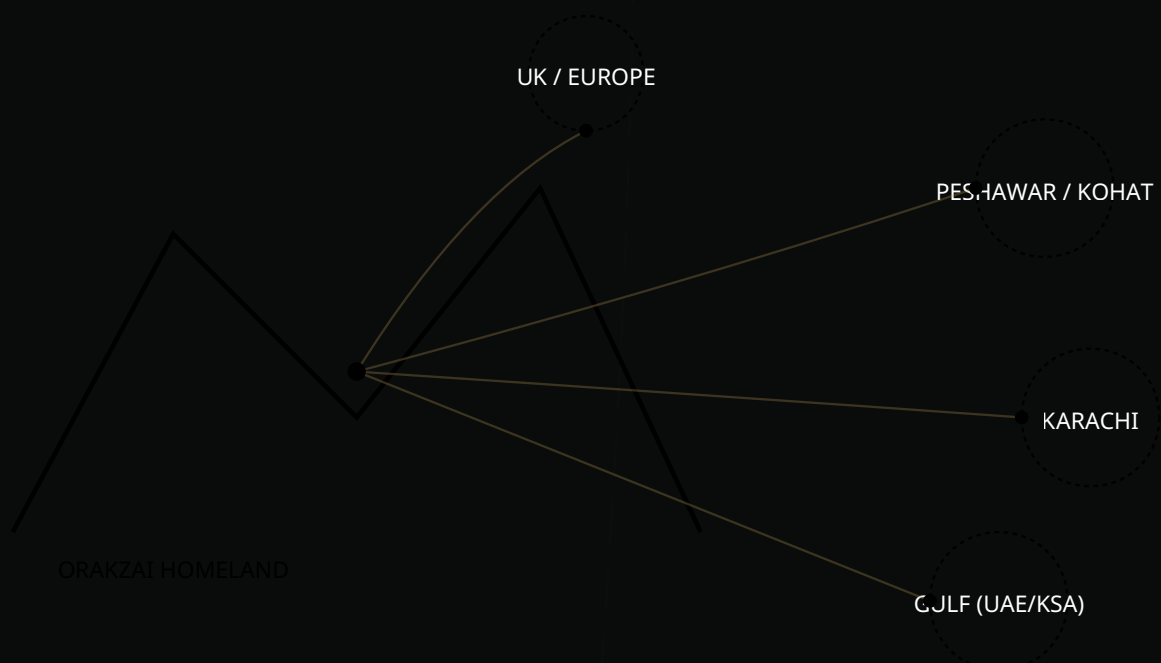


ORAKZAI DIASPORA

“Distance can change where people live without deciding where they belong.”

Not every Orakzai family lives in the place where its story began. Some families have moved to nearby towns. Some have built lives in Pakistan’s major cities. Some have crossed national borders for work or education. Others were forced to leave because of conflict. For some, migration was temporary. For others, movement became permanent. Yet distance does not necessarily erase belonging. A family can live far from the mountains and still remember its village. A child can grow up in a city and still learn the language of their grandparents. A household can build a new life while maintaining relationships with relatives, traditions and memories connected to home. The Orakzai diaspora is therefore not one single experience. It is a collection of journeys.



“The global network of Orakzai journeys.”

WHAT IS A DIASPORA?

A diaspora is more than simply living away from an ancestral homeland. It is a living social network maintained through memory, identity, language, and economic ties. While a migrant moves from one place to another, a diaspora community exists in multiple places at once—connected by a shared origin and a continued commitment to the homeland.⁶

HOME → MOVEMENT → NEW PLACE → DIASPORA

“The conceptual progression from movement to diaspora.”

CONFLICT AND DISPLACEMENT

A significant part of the modern Orakzai diaspora was created through conflict-induced internal displacement. As military operations intensified in Orakzai Agency in late 2009, thousands of families were forced to seek sanctuary in neighbouring districts. This movement was not a choice of opportunity, but a necessity of survival.^{1 2}

40,000

DISPLACED (DEC 2009)

2,400

FAMILIES TO HANGU

23,000

HH RETURNED (2010)

HOME

DISPLACEMENT

HOST COMMUNITY

RETURN

SETTLEMENT

“The pathways of internal displacement and its outcomes.”

CLASSIFICATION OF MOVEMENT

Not all migration is the same phenomenon. Understanding the Orakzai diaspora requires distinguishing between different types of movement, each with its own drivers, scope, and impact on the community.^{5 7}

TYPE	DRIVER	GEOGRAPHIC SCOPE	CONFIDENCE
Conflict Displacement	Security / Operations	Neighboring Districts	High (UNHCR)
Economic Migration	Employment / Trade	Karachi / Gulf Hubs	High (Academic)
Educational	Higher Education	Peshawar / Islamabad	Medium (Observed)
Urbanization	Services / Housing	Peshawar / Kohat	Medium (Census)

URBAN HUBS: KARACHI AND PESHAWAR

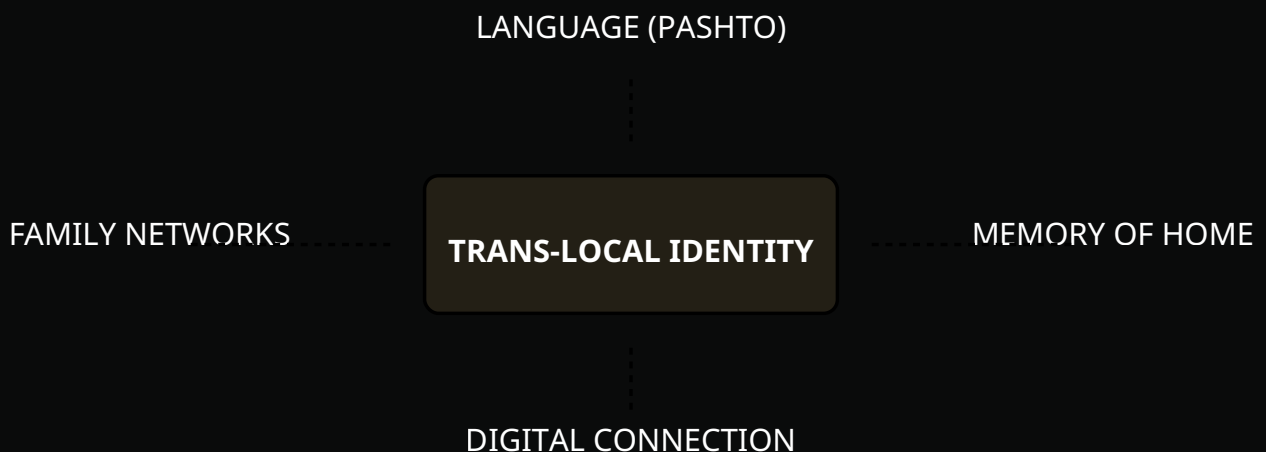
Karachi remains the largest Orakzai diaspora hub outside the northwest, with significant concentrations in Sohrab Goth, Banaras, and Pathan Colony. In these urban environments, Orakzai migrants are heavily involved in the transport and retail sectors, creating economic networks that support families back in the homeland. Peshawar, meanwhile, serves as a center for education and professional settlement.^{6 7}



“The national and international urban network of Orakzai communities.”

MAINTAINING IDENTITY ACROSS DISTANCE

The Orakzai identity is not lost in the city; it is adapted. Family networks, the Pashto language, and digital connectivity allow the diaspora to participate in tribal life from thousands of kilometres away. A return visit for a wedding or a funeral is not just a trip; it is a renewal of belonging.⁶



“The pillars of Orakzai identity in the diaspora context.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

The Orakzai diaspora is a collection of journeys, but every journey has a common anchor. When I meet Orakzai people in Karachi or Dubai, I don't see people who have left their identity behind; I see people who have carried it with them into a larger world. They speak the language of the mountains in the middle of a concrete city. They send the fruits of their labor back to build schools and houses in the valley. They prove that being Orakzai is not about where you live, but about how you carry the values of your elders into new environments. Our community is no longer confined to our mountains; it is a global network of resilience. We are everywhere, yet we are always home.

“WE ARE EVERYWHERE, YET WE ARE ALWAYS HOME.”

ORAKZAI DIASPORA ANALYSIS
